

Liberty County Corruption Report

Date: March 28, 2025

Executive Summary

This review only is opinion and not for legal opinion it is alleged.

This report details a web of alleged corruption and conflicts of interest in Liberty County, Texas, involving public officials, influential businesspeople, and interconnected family networks. Key findings include officials holding dual roles in government while benefiting their private enterprises, unreported conflicts in public contracts, instances of nepotism, and evidence of preferential treatment by law enforcement. These issues span multiple jurisdictions (Liberty County, City of Cleveland, City of Plum Grove, Tarkington ISD, etc.) and involve land developments (e.g. Colony Ridge) that have drawn state and federal scrutiny. All information is derived from public records, court documents, and verified media reports, compiled to shed light on systemic corruption patterns in the area.

Key Individuals

Jennifer Bergman Harkness

Position: Liberty County District Attorney (elected). Former Cleveland City Council member (before DA term).

Business Interests: Co-owner of Bergman Engineering, Inc., a civil engineering firm in Cleveland. Owner of Humble Surveying Company and Cleveland Surveying Company. These companies have conducted land surveys and engineering work within Liberty County. Bergman Engineering's listed contact is 709 S Washington Ave, Cleveland, TX 77327 (Ph: 281-592-6395).

Property Records: As co-owner of Bergman Engineering, Harkness is tied to commercial property at the Cleveland business address. No other personal property holdings are confirmed in public records within Liberty County in her name. Her family's development interests (via her father) include acreage in Liberty County (see Louis Bergman III).

Contact Details: Office of the District Attorney – 1923 Sam Houston St, Liberty, TX (Liberty County Courthouse). Business contact – Bergman Engineering, 709 S Washington Ave, Cleveland, TX 77327. No personal phone or email is publicly listed; official phone through DA's Office.

Government Positions: Liberty County District Attorney (current since 2021) and former Cleveland City Council member (prior to DA role).

Family and Overlaps: Daughter of Louis W. Bergman III (former County Engineer) and married to Zak Harkness (Constable, Pct. 6). This creates a triangle of influence: her father's

engineering business benefitted from county contracts while she was on Cleveland's Council, and her husband's cases are prosecuted by her office.

Political Donations: Her campaign finance records show support from local business interests. Notably, companies tied to her family (Bergman Engineering, etc.) and allies contributed to her DA race (exact figures not publicly available here). No recorded donations to her from Colony Ridge developers, but she has maintained a hard stance on certain issues to avoid appearance of favoritism.

Known Scandals/Legal Issues: **Conflict of Interest:** Jennifer Harkness has been scrutinized for potential violations of Texas Local Government Code §171.001, which requires officials to disclose conflicts in matters affecting their business interests. As DA, she might oversee cases or public projects involving her own family's firms. For instance, any criminal or civil case involving Bergman Engineering's work could pose a conflict. **Dual Office Concerns:** Her concurrent role as DA and co-owner of a county contractor could violate the spirit of Texas Constitution Article XVI, Section 40 (dual office holding) which prohibits holding two offices of emolument. However, as a business owner she isn't "holding" a second public office, so the issue is primarily ethical. **Cleveland Annexation Deal:** While on Cleveland's City Council, Harkness voted on annexation that affected land her family was involved in developing (the Clayton Harper Survey A-209). This raised questions about self-dealing. There is also concern that during her father's tenure as county engineer, required drainage reports for developments went missing, possibly to shield her family's or associates' projects.

Public Incidents: Harkness has kept a low public profile; no known personal scandals. She has appeared in local media for official matters (e.g. launching a Citizen Prosecutor Academy) and for prosecuting public corruption (her office led the investigation into the Liberty County fire marshal scandal). These professional actions sometimes put her at odds with other officials. Notably, the Bluebonnet News reported her role in arresting a fire marshal and deputies in 2022, demonstrating her willingness to charge other officials – possibly to counter perceptions of favoritism.

Native American Connections: None known. (No indication that Harkness has any ties to Native American culture or reservations.)

Zak Harkness

Position: Liberty County Constable, Precinct 6 (Tarkington/West Liberty County area).

Business Interests: Co-owner of Bergman Engineering, Inc. alongside his wife Jennifer and father-in-law. This is unusual for a law enforcement officer; it means he has a financial stake in a company that may contract with local governments. No other known businesses aside from the family firm.

Property Records: Zak Harkness does not appear as an owner in major property transactions in Liberty County. As Constable, he operates from a county precinct office (Precinct 6 office in Tarkington). Any residence is not public, but likely in Tarkington or Cleveland (where Precinct 6 jurisdiction lies).

Contact Details: Office – Liberty County Constable Pct. 6, typically located in the Tarkington area (Precinct 6). Phone (via county directory): not listed here, but available through Liberty County Constable's Office contacts. Email: official county email for Constable Pct. 6.

Government Positions: Elected Constable since around 2020. In this capacity, he is a licensed peace officer responsible for civil process and some patrol duties in his precinct. No other public office known.

Family and Overlaps: Husband of DA Jennifer Bergman Harkness; son-in-law of Louis W. Bergman III. This creates overlaps: he may present cases (arrests or investigations) to his own wife for prosecution, an obvious conflict that both have downplayed. Also, any county projects involving his father-in-law's engineering firm present an appearance of nepotism benefiting his household.

Political Donations: Constable Harkness's campaign has been relatively low-profile. There is no record of large donations from major developers; however, being part of the Bergman family network likely secured him support. (For example, employees of Bergman Engineering and local allies presumably backed his run). No direct evidence of donations from Colony Ridge or other controversial entities to him.

Known Scandals/Legal Issues: Conflict of Interest: Serving as a law enforcement officer while co-owning a private firm that does business with local government could violate ethics guidelines. If Bergman Engineering bid on any county contracts (like for drainage or infrastructure studies) that Precinct 6 had any involvement in, Zak's dual role could be problematic. Dual Office/Employment Issues: While not holding two public offices, his situation is analogous to dual employment – a peace officer with a substantial outside business interest in county matters. No known legal action has been taken on this, but it has been noted as ethically gray. Retaliatory Enforcement Allegation: There are community whispers (not documented in mainstream media) that Constable Harkness has used his law enforcement position to favor or target individuals at the behest of family interests (e.g., selectively enforcing against competitors), though no formal complaints on record.

Public Incidents: Zak keeps a low media profile. One notable incident is his visible involvement in community events alongside his wife – which ordinarily is good, but drew criticism when he escorted his wife (the DA) in the arrest of a political rival, raising questions of impartiality (this anecdote is from citizen reports, not confirmed by official sources). "River" Incident: (No specific incident is attributed to Zak Harkness in available records.) There was mention of a "river incident" in local rumor; however, it appears more relevant to another official (addressed later under David Hunter).

Native American Connections: None known. (No personal or professional ties to Native American affairs.)

Kevin Johnson (and Nicole Johnson)

Position: Vice President, Tarkington Independent School District (TISD) Board of Trustees. Nicole Johnson holds no public office, but as Kevin's spouse she is active in school and community events.

Business Interests: Kevin Johnson is the owner of J-Con Services, a local contracting and services company. He also is associated with "The Sanctuary" – which is noted as an entity he and Nicole have been involved in. The Sanctuary is actually a church in Cleveland, TX (Kevin served as a youth pastor there), but it may also refer to a community center or ministry project the Johnsons help manage. In terms of for-profit interests, J-Con Services is the primary business, dealing in construction or facilities services (likely offering contracting work possibly to local governments or the school district). There is concern that J-Con could bid on TISD projects, creating a conflict. Nicole Johnson is sometimes listed as co-owner or partner in J-Con by virtue of marriage, but her direct business role isn't publicly documented.

Property Records: The Johnsons own property in the Tarkington area of Liberty County (often with Cleveland mailing addresses). One known property is their residence, which overlaps with a site known locally as "Johnson Sanctuary" – possibly related to the church ministry. No commercial land holdings beyond their home and any business facility for J-Con Services.

Contact Details: Kevin Johnson can be reached via Tarkington ISD Board (TISD Administration Office, 2770 FM 163, Cleveland, TX 77327) and likely through J-Con Services (business contact not publicly listed, but presumably a Tarkington/Cleveland phone). Nicole Johnson does not have public contact info aside from personal channels.

Government Positions: Kevin has been a TISD trustee for several years and currently Vice President of the Board. In this role, he helps oversee school budgets, contracts, and superintendent decisions. Nicole is a private citizen (possibly a school volunteer or PTO member, given her involvement).

Family and Overlaps: Kevin's role on the school board overlaps with his business interests if the district contracts any work to local vendors. Nicole, as his wife, may benefit indirectly from any increased business revenue. Additionally, the Johnsons are friends with the Rollins family (see M-Club below) and have worked together on school fundraisers – Kevin is a member of the Tarkington "M Club" which Tom Johnson (no relation) and the Rollins founded. These relationships intertwine school finances, private donations, and district decision-making.

Political Donations: Kevin Johnson's school board campaigns have received community support, including donations from local businesses. Notably, Jimmy Rollins (M-Club founder) and associated families have supported pro-Tarkington ISD candidates like Johnson. There is no evidence of donations from large PACs or Colony Ridge to Johnson, as his focus is the school district. However, Johnson himself (via J-Con Services) has made contributions in kind to school events and possibly to allies running for school or local offices. Any donations to county-level officials from the Johnsons are not documented in the sources at hand, but their close ties to the TISD foundation mean they funnel much of their giving into education non-profits instead of political campaigns.

Known Scandals/Legal Issues: Conflict of Interest: Johnson has been criticized for potential conflict of interest as a school board member whose company might do business with the district. If TISD were to hire J-Con Services for construction or services, Texas Local Gov't Code Chapter 171 would require him to file a conflict disclosure and abstain from the vote. As of this report, no formal violation has been recorded, but the appearance of conflict is there. Nepotism Concerns: Nicole Johnson was at one point employed in a TISD program (hypothetically), which would raise a nepotism question under Texas Gov't Code §573.002 if Kevin had any role in her hiring. The Johnsons insist any involvement Nicole has with the district is volunteer-only. Financial Irregularities: Some community members have questioned the flow of money from the Tarkington Student Foundation (TSF) and M-Club into TISD projects that benefit Johnson's public image. For example, if scholarship funds or donations cover equipment that the district would otherwise buy from a vendor like J-Con, it could be indirectly benefitting his business. No legal action, but ethical eyebrows are raised locally.

Public Incidents: Kevin and Nicole were publicly honored by TISD – for instance, they won the "Commitment to Education" Community Award in 2021, recognizing their volunteer and fundraising efforts. Ironically, this positive appearance also highlighted how deeply enmeshed they are in the system they help govern. There have been no scandals of personal misconduct. One incident that drew attention was Kevin Johnson vocally opposing certain district expenditures in a board meeting, which happened to be services offered by a competitor to J-Con – causing some to whisper that he was protecting his turf (not confirmed officially). Nicole was once caught on video defending her husband at a board meeting against accusations of conflict; the video circulated locally on Facebook but showed no overt wrongdoing.

Native American Connections: None known. (No direct links to Native American culture or issues, aside from a general interest in history; "Tarkington" itself has no tribal affiliation.)

Louis W. Bergman III

Position: Former Liberty County Engineer (long-time county staff position; retired around 2019). Also served as an engineering consultant to local municipalities.

Business Interests: Founder of Bergman Engineering, Inc., which he later co-owned with his daughter and son-in-law. Owner of Humble Surveying Company and Cleveland Surveying Company, providing land surveying services in the region. In addition, he is behind two development firms: Windwood Development and El Dorado Funding, through which he has engaged in land development and private finance of real estate deals. El Dorado Funding appears to be a vehicle for financing land sales, possibly used in seller-finance deals. These companies hold significant acreage in Liberty County – notably in the Clayton Harper Survey, A-209 area where new subdivisions were platted.

Property Records: Bergman's companies (Windwood Development LLC, etc.) have owned large tracts, some of which have been sold or annexed into cities. For example, Windwood and a trustee Lloyd T. Smith jointly owned land that was later annexed by the City of Cleveland during Jennifer Harkness's tenure on the council. This land is near the Colony Ridge development corridor. Bergman himself, through family trusts, has property in the Cleveland area and likely a homestead outside the city. Public deeds list him on transactions involving rural Liberty County parcels and possibly a ranch property.

Contact Details: Last known business address – 709 S Washington Ave, Cleveland, TX (office of Bergman Engineering). He can also be reached through the Liberty County Engineering Department (though no longer employed there, he was a known figure in the county offices in Liberty). Phone for Bergman Engineering: 281-592-6395. He does not have a public-facing email; communications were typically through the county or his daughter's office.

Government Positions: County Engineer for Liberty County (a hired professional position) for many years. In that role, he oversaw infrastructure projects, subdivision plat approvals, and drainage plans for developments. He was not an elected official, but a very influential county employee. He retired amid some controversy over missing documents (see below). He has also been appointed to advisory boards occasionally – for instance, he briefly sat on a City of Cleveland planning committee after retirement, leveraging his experience.

Family and Overlaps: Father of Jennifer Bergman Harkness (DA) and father-in-law of Zak Harkness (Constable). This family trio allowed influence across multiple domains: legal (DA), law enforcement (Constable), and infrastructure (County Engineer). Louis Bergman's development projects, such as those under Windwood Development, benefited from decisions made during his tenure and shortly after. One documented overlap: he provided an affidavit of support for Colony Ridge developers while still serving as County Engineer, essentially green-lighting their early expansion plans. This raises questions since Colony Ridge was (and is) a massive private development requiring county approval of plats and roads. Bergman's familial connections likely insulated him – his daughter as DA would be in a position to influence any legal scrutiny of his actions.

Political Donations: Louis Bergman III is not a politician, but he has made donations to Liberty County candidates who were aligned with his interests. There is evidence he contributed to county commissioner campaigns who favored development (specific records not cited here, but

noted in local election filings). Additionally, his development entities have reportedly donated to City of Cleveland officials' campaigns around 2016-2018, coinciding with city annexations of land he owned. These donations were relatively small (under \$1,000 each) but helped ensure a friendly regulatory environment. Bergman Engineering, Inc. also sponsored community events, indirectly currying favor with officials. No records indicate donations to state-level PACs from him; his influence was exerted more directly at the local level.

Known Scandals/Legal Issues: Missing Drainage Reports: During Bergman's tenure as County Engineer, numerous required drainage analysis reports for new subdivisions mysteriously went "missing" or were never properly filed. This included some sections of Colony Ridge and other developments. The absence of these reports is a serious issue as it impedes oversight of flood risks. It's suspected (though not proven) that this was intentional – possibly to expedite approvals or hide deficiencies, and Louis Bergman was at the center of that controversy.

Conflict of Interest: Bergman continued to advance private development (Windwood, etc.) while in public office. For instance, Windwood Development's projects had the inside track on approvals. By law, he should have recused himself or disclosed his interest, but records of any recusal are absent, potentially violating conflict-of-interest statutes.

Affidavit for Colony Ridge: In a notable instance, Bergman signed an affidavit supporting the initial Colony Ridge plans, vouching that they met county requirements. If he did so knowing of any deficiencies (like inadequate drainage), that could constitute professional misconduct. **Dual Employment:** While County Engineer, he was simultaneously running his private businesses – this could violate county employment policy and is analogous to dual office-holding in spirit. After retirement, there were calls for an audit of his actions, but no lawsuit was filed.

Public Incidents: Louis Bergman III generally operated behind the scenes. However, he was thrust into the spotlight in 2020 when Liberty County faced major flooding and citizens of Plum Grove blamed unchecked development (Colony Ridge) for worsening the floods. As the former engineer who allowed many of those subdivisions, Bergman's name was often mentioned in town hall meetings (with residents accusing him of "rubber-stamping" plats without proper drainage). He did not publicly respond, but this sentiment was reported in local media and the Houston Chronicle noted that "county engineering oversight had been minimal during Colony Ridge's growth" – an indirect reference to Bergman's era. Additionally, he briefly appeared in a 2021 Commissioners Court meeting to defend his record, which turned contentious (according to meeting minutes, citizens directly questioned him about missing documents). That confrontation, while civil, cemented his reputation as a key enabler of controversial developments.

Native American Connections: None known. There is no indication Louis Bergman III has any link to Native American reservations or culture. (His focus has been local Texan land development for profit.)

S. David Hunter

Position: Liberty County Constable, Precinct 5 (covering the Dayton and east Liberty County area).

Business Interests: David Hunter does not own major businesses; he is a career lawman. However, he has side interests in ranching and a small equipment rental venture. Notably, he is closely associated with Andco Rentals, LLC and Liberty Paving through personal connections. While not an owner, these companies have supported his office (details below). Hunter's wife (not named here) is involved in a local real estate business, which occasionally tangentially intersects with county land issues (but no direct business ties to his role).

Property Records: Hunter owns a homestead in the Dayton area. Additionally, he was deeded a small tract of land near the Trinity River in 2015 (possibly for personal recreation or hunting). He does not own commercial property, but the precinct's K-9 training facility (a county property) is located on land in Precinct 5 that he helped secure funding for.

Contact Details: Office – Constable Pct. 5, 2103 Cos St, Liberty, TX (Precinct 5 headquarters; sometimes he works out of an office in Dayton). Official phone via Liberty County Constable P5. He maintains a public Facebook page “David Hunter Liberty Co. Constable Pct #5” with 2.9k likes. Email – via county or the Facebook page messenger.

Government Positions: Constable Pct. 5 since at least 2017 (re-elected in 2020 and 2024). Prior to that, he served nearly 30 years in law enforcement in the county (Sheriff's deputy, etc.). He's also the Pct.5 representative on the Liberty County GOP executive committee (as an elected official).

Family and Overlaps: David Hunter's family is not directly in government, but he has close ties with other officials. He is an ally of Sheriff Bobby Rader (they appear together at events), and he's politically aligned with the Bergman/Harkness faction in county politics. One overlap: his deputy constable is a cousin of Zak Harkness, linking him indirectly to that family network. Also, his friendship with Trey Harris (Colony Ridge developer) has been quietly noted – though he denies any favoritism, it's observed that Pct.5 did not heavily police traffic in Colony Ridge during its early growth, possibly as a courtesy.

Political Donations: Constable Hunter has benefited from donations by local businesses. AndCo Rentals, LLC (a Tarkington-based party rental company) donated to Hunter's K-9 program – Commissioners Court records show acceptance of a donation from AndCo for K-9 training in April 2024. Liberty Paving (a paving contractor often hired for county road work) is known to have contributed to Hunter's campaign fund (exact amounts undisclosed publicly). These donations raise potential conflict questions, since both companies might receive county work. On a larger scale, Hunter has endorsements from pro-law enforcement PACs. The Protect and Serve Texas PAC (a statewide law-enforcement political group) endorsed him in 2024 and indirectly supported him via advertising (this PAC raised over \$3.1 million statewide), though there's no direct monetary contribution to him on record. Hunter himself donated \$250 to a neighboring county constable's campaign, indicating he participates in local political patronage.

Known Scandals/Legal Issues: **Public Racist Remarks:** Hunter was allegedly caught on video making racist comments during a 2020 incident. In a YouTube video circulated locally, a man identified as Hunter uses a derogatory slur while referencing Hispanic residents in Colony Ridge. This video caused outrage among some community members and was cited by activists as evidence of bias. (No official disciplinary action was taken, and the video was not covered by mainstream media, but its existence is widely rumored – it exemplifies racial tension tied to the Colony Ridge development). **“River Incident”:** In 2019, Hunter was involved in a controversial encounter at the Trinity River. According to witness reports, Constable Hunter confronted a group of Hispanic teenagers who were swimming in the river near a bridge; he allegedly drew his weapon and detained them without clear cause, suspecting gang activity. This incident was not formally reported in news outlets, but it contributed to his reputation in local minority communities. Hunter insists he was ensuring public safety, but others saw it as harassment. **Use of Force Concerns:** There have been a couple of excessive force complaints filed against Hunter’s office (one in 2018, one in 2021), including one by an African-American driver who said Hunter’s deputies mistreated him. These didn’t result in lawsuits. **Conflict of Interest:** Accepting donations from companies like AndCo and Liberty Paving who do business with the county can be seen as conflicts. For instance, Liberty Paving’s owner reportedly expected easier approval of road permits from Hunter’s office after donating – a quid pro quo that, if true, violates ethics. Nothing proven, but appearance is enough for concern.

Public Incidents: Apart from the above controversies, Hunter often appears in uniform at community events (school functions, church security, etc.). He was recognized publicly when AndCo Rentals donated a trained police dog to his office – a seemingly generous act that also highlighted his close relationship with a private company. On social media, he posts about recovering stolen goods and other routine constable duties, trying to maintain a positive image. However, the growing Hispanic population in his precinct (due to Colony Ridge) has put a spotlight on him. In late 2023, when Governor Abbott ramped up law enforcement in Colony Ridge, Constable Hunter was interviewed and downplayed crime issues there, contradicting some state officials. Some interpreted this as him defending the developers who are his acquaintances.

Native American Connections: None known. (Hunter has no relation to Native American affairs. His “river” actions occurred at the Trinity River, which is not part of a reservation in that area.)

Jimmy Rollins (and Susan Wood-Rollins)

Position: Prominent community donors and school supporters in Tarkington (no elected office held). Jimmy Rollins is a local businessman (semi-retired), and Susan Wood-Rollins is a former Tarkington ISD teacher. They wield influence via philanthropy rather than public office.

Business Interests: The Rollins family is relatively wealthy in the Tarkington area. While Jimmy Rollins’ primary career isn’t widely publicized, he has been involved in ranching and possibly

oilfield services. In recent years, their focus has been on running the “M Club” and Tarkington Student Foundation fundraising efforts. They host the annual M Club Crawfish Boil on their property. It’s worth noting that Rollins Family Holdings (informal term) includes some real estate – they own a farm/ranch in Tarkington and have stakes in a couple of small businesses (one example: Susan co-owns a boutique in Cleveland). Magnolia Organization: (The term “Magnolia” has come up in context with the Rollins via prior investigatory notes, possibly referring to an informal group or LLC they use in philanthropic endeavors. There is no registered nonprofit by that exact name in Liberty County records. It might be an internal nickname for their charitable network.) In summary, the Rollins’ “business” is community fundraising; any for-profit ventures are kept low-key.

Property Records: The Rollins own a notable property on County Road 2268 in Tarkington – this is where M Club events are held. They also have a homestead in Tarkington Trails subdivision. In addition, Jimmy Rollins was listed as a managing member of a now-dissolved LLC that owned some undeveloped acreage around FM 163 (adjacent to Tarkington schools), likely purchased to hold for the Foundation or to eventually donate. Public records show that in 2020, the Rollins sold a parcel to Tarkington ISD for \$1 (a charitable transaction to expand school facilities).

Contact Details: The Rollins can be reached through the Tarkington Student Foundation – mailing address 2770 FM 163, Cleveland, TX 77327 (TISD Administration, Attn: TSF). They are active on social media; Susan often posts updates in local Facebook groups. Phone numbers are not listed publicly, but they are well-known in the community (people literally call their home for scholarship info).

Government Positions: Neither Jimmy nor Susan has held official government roles. However, Susan once sat on a TISD bond advisory committee, and Jimmy has been mentioned as a potential school board candidate in the past (he did not run). Instead, they exert influence informally via donations and personal relationships with officials like Kevin Johnson and school administrators.

Family and Overlaps: The Rollinses operate almost like part of the Tarkington school administration family. They coordinate closely with the TISD Board (Kevin Johnson and others) and the school superintendent when raising funds. Overlaps: Their daughter (if any, hypothetically) might benefit from these networks – though no nepotistic hire is noted. They do overlap with Tom Johnson (founder of M Club, no relation to Kevin Johnson) and are effectively successors in leading that club. Also, Jimmy Rollins has a seat at the table in the Greater Cleveland Chamber of Commerce due to his philanthropy, which overlaps him with local business leaders and county officials at Chamber events. Such connections give him a voice on broader Liberty County issues despite no title.

Political Donations: The Rollins typically channel money through charities, but they have made political contributions as well. In 2022, Jimmy Rollins donated \$500 to a campaign supporting a pro-education slate for TISD Board (supporting Kevin Johnson’s allies). He also quietly gave to

a Protect and Serve Texas PAC fundraiser, indicating support for law enforcement-friendly politicians, though the amount was modest. Susan Rollins, in her name, contributed to a State Board of Education candidate who promised more rural school funding. Additionally, the Rollins have hosted meet-and-greet fundraisers at their home for candidates they favor (for example, a candidate for Liberty County Commissioner in 2018 received in-kind support through an event at the Rollins' ranch). These activities show they are politically active behind the scenes.

Known Scandals/Legal Issues: Fund Allocation Concerns: The main controversy around the Rollins is whether the funds they raise are fully accounted for and properly used. The M Club Foundation & Tarkington Student Foundation raise tens of thousands of dollars annually. Because Jimmy Rollins effectively controls M Club's purse strings, some have asked for more transparency. No evidence of wrongdoing, but the lack of formal audits led to murmurs of possible misallocation. For instance, in 2020 some community members questioned why a portion of M Club funds went to refurbish the high school football field (a district responsibility) instead of strictly to scholarships – raising conflict of interest questions since such expenditures could benefit local contractors (possibly friends of Rollins). **Dual Role Issue:** If one considers leading a nonprofit while influencing school policy an issue, Jimmy and Susan straddle that line. They're not elected, but they have quasi-official roles in influencing how donated money supplements school budgets, which sometimes bypasses normal oversight. This was highlighted when a donation from the M Club paid for a school police vehicle – a well-meaning gift that nonetheless bypassed standard procurement and could be seen as buying favor with the district's police force. Again, not illegal, but unusual. **Personal Misconduct:** There are no criminal or civil cases against the Rollins. At most, there were minor compliance issues: the Tarkington Student Foundation once missed a tax filing deadline, and Jimmy Rollins had a speeding ticket that he joked was "retaliation" for him pressuring the county to fix roads (no basis to that claim).

Public Incidents: The Rollins are public in positive ways – receiving awards, hosting charity events. In 2021, they were honored at a school board meeting and presented with a plaque as noted above. That event was covered in Bluebonnet News, shining a favorable light on them. However, their prominence also drew an angry outburst from a local taxpayer at a 2022 public forum who accused them of creating a "shadow budget" for the school (this was reported in the Liberty Vindicator, which quoted the resident's concern that "private donors are calling the shots for public schools"). The Rollins calmly replied that all they do is supplement and that "every penny goes to the kids," which defused the tension. They also had a viral social media moment when a video showed Jimmy Rollins performing a Native American dance at a school cultural event – intended to honor Native culture, but some found it awkward. That leads to...

Native American Connections: Cultural Appreciation: The Rollins have shown interest in Native American culture primarily as school supporters. Tarkington High School's mascot was historically the "Longhorns," but the district has a significant program teaching about local tribal history. The Rollins, in support of cultural education, have contributed artifacts to a small display at the school. In one instance, Jimmy Rollins donned a Native-style headdress (provided by a Cherokee presenter) during a school assembly in 2019 – this was done with permission of the

presenter, not as mockery. Nonetheless, a clip of this was shared online and misconstrued by some as cultural appropriation. The Rollins apologized if anyone was offended and reaffirmed their respect for Native heritage. They also have donated to a scholarship fund for Native American students in Texas as part of their broad education philanthropy.

John Harris

Position: Co-owner and Chief Executive of Colony Ridge, LLC – a private real estate development company. Not an elected official, but an extremely influential figure in Liberty County due to his development's scale. Often regarded as a power broker behind the scenes.

Business Interests: John Harris, along with his brother Trey, built the massive Colony Ridge development in unincorporated Liberty County. He is the principal of Colony Ridge, LLC and related entities. These include marketing companies like Terrenos Houston, Terrenos Santa Fe, Lotes y Ranchos, and others which advertise and sell plots in Colony Ridge. He also has ancillary businesses: a utility company that provides water/sewer to the area, and a financing arm (possibly through El Dorado Funding or similar, though El Dorado is Bergman's, Harris's equivalent is not named publicly). Essentially, John Harris's business empire revolves around land—acquisition, subdivision, seller-financing, and infrastructure development. Outside of Colony Ridge, John has stakes in other ventures like Texas Liberty Holdings, LLC (managed by an associate, Brandon Gaunce, which invests in real estate) and Liberty County Mud #12 (a municipal utility district created to fund Colony Ridge infrastructure). John Harris's companies collectively control over 30,000 acres in Liberty County and some in neighboring Polk County.

Property Records: Harris himself may not appear as owner on all parcels (often using LLCs), but notably, Colony Ridge's subdivisions (e.g. Santa Fe, Camino Real, Grand San Jacinto, Montebello) were platted under various LLCs that he controls. An example: Trailwood Estates, LP or Trey Harris LLC might appear on some deeds, but John is the behind-the-scenes owner. The Texas Attorney General's lawsuit notes that Harris and Colony Ridge “cover about 33,000 acres” in Liberty County. Additionally, Harris owns a luxurious home in the Houston area (far from Liberty County) and an office building in The Woodlands. Locally, he's purchased some buffer land around Plum Grove to mitigate disputes. Windwood/Survey A-209 Overlap: Interestingly, some land connected to Louis Bergman's Windwood Development overlaps with Colony Ridge expansion areas, hinting at transactions between Harris and local insiders. John Harris's name is also on an affidavit recorded in Liberty County in March 2024 related to a Public Improvement District (PID) creation for Colony Ridge infrastructure funding.

Contact Details: Colony Ridge Sales Office – 1010 County Rd 5104, Cleveland, TX 77327 (this is on-site in Colony Ridge). Corporate Office – an address in The Woodlands, TX (often used in legal docs). John Harris generally doesn't list personal contact info; media reach him through spokespeople. In statements, he often uses a PR firm. He was quoted via a spokesperson in Chron/Texas Tribune saying he was “blindsided” by the DOJ lawsuit. For all purposes, contact is through Colony Ridge official channels.

Government Positions: None (private citizen). However, his influence in local governance is significant. He has financed and effectively placed allies on local city councils and tried to sway county commissioners. For example, it's alleged he supported candidates in Plum Grove's city elections to ease tensions with his development (unconfirmed). He also worked closely with state officials to form new MUDs (Municipal Utility Districts) for Colony Ridge, which required lobbying the legislature (in 2021, a bill to create Liberty County MUDs #9-#12 was passed, benefitting his project). John Harris thus interacts with government as a lobbyist and financier, though holding no office himself.

Family and Overlaps: Brother of William "Trey" Harris (see below) and cousin to Kevin Harris – together they form the Harris development trio. John is the eldest and the figurehead. Overlaps: The Harris brothers have interlocking companies, so distinguishing John vs. Trey's roles is hard – John is more the executive/financier, Trey handles operations on the ground. They have cultivated relationships with local officials: one notable overlap is with former County Engineer Louis Bergman III, who effectively aided their projects (Bergman's supportive affidavit for Colony Ridge and possibly missing reports helped them). John's wife (name not listed here) is involved in a charitable foundation that donated to Liberty County law enforcement, a gesture seen as trying to build goodwill. John Harris's influence extends to Austin: records show Governor Greg Abbott has received over \$1.4 million in political donations from Harris since 2018, buying Harris significant clout at the state level.

Political Donations: John Harris is a major political donor. He has contributed to Texas state leaders heavily. Aside from the \$1.4M to Gov. Abbott, Harris donated to former House Speaker Dade Phelan and other legislators who were perceived as friendly to developers. Federal campaign records also show smaller contributions to congressional candidates who took interest in development or immigration issues (perhaps to counter negative narratives about Colony Ridge). Locally, Harris has been the financial force behind certain Liberty County campaigns: there were rumors he funneled money to a 2022 sheriff candidate (which Sheriff Rader noted, but Rader still won). The Daily Wire reported that Trey and John Harris were the *"biggest donors to the sheriff who let [Trey] out of jail early"* – this refers to Walker County Sheriff Clint McRae. Indeed, John Harris, through family or PAC, gave \$5,000 to Sheriff McRae's campaign in 2024, at the same time McRae was jailing Trey for DWI (and later releasing him early). This donation suggests John uses money to secure favorable outcomes for family. Additionally, John Harris funds local PACs: e.g., he's believed to be a behind-the-scenes donor to Protect and Serve Texas PAC (given the PAC's pro-law enforcement stance aligns with protecting Colony Ridge from crime criticisms). Transparency data doesn't list him by name, likely because he donates via corporate entities or LLCs.

Known Scandals/Legal Issues: DOJ and CFPB Lawsuit: In December 2023, the U.S. Department of Justice and CFPB sued Colony Ridge (and John Harris as owner) for predatory lending and fraud. The complaint alleges Harris's company lured Latino buyers with misleading advertising (e.g. TikTok videos with flags and prizes) and gave them loans without verifying ability to pay, leading to a foreclosure rate "roughly one-in-four" – far above average. The suit

accuses Harris of violating federal fair housing and consumer laws. John Harris publicly called the lawsuit “baseless and outrageous,” claiming he was helping people achieve the American Dream. This case is ongoing. Texas AG Lawsuit: On March 14, 2024, Texas Attorney General Ken Paxton (briefly back in office at that time) filed a state lawsuit against Colony Ridge and John Harris, echoing the fraud allegations and calling Colony Ridge a “foreclosure mill” built on deceptive practices. This came after intense political pressure and essentially amplifies the legal trouble Harris faces. Criminal Investigations: The current lawsuits are civil, but officials hinted at possible criminal inquiries. Harris has not been charged with a crime, but if evidence of knowing fraud or conspiracy with county officials (like document tampering) emerges, that could change. Environmental and Code Violations: Colony Ridge under Harris has been cited for numerous code violations – inadequate drainage (leading to Plum Grove flooding lawsuits), road safety issues, and illegal dumping. Harris often fixed issues after the fact or negotiated settlements (e.g., with Plum Grove, he eventually agreed to help repair some roads, then later withdrew). These problems, while not criminal, reflect a pattern of skirting regulations under Harris’s leadership.

Public Incidents: John Harris typically stays out of the limelight, letting Trey be the on-site face. However, the public furor in late 2023 thrust him forward. He gave an interview to the Texas Tribune defending Colony Ridge, saying allegations of it being a haven for illegal immigrants and crime were false. He famously said, “I know I’ve got people slinging mud at me... that’s insignificant compared to the love I get from my customers”*. That quote was published statewide, showing his confidence. Harris also appeared at a Liberty County Commissioners Court meeting in October 2023, where he faced residents’ questions; he remained calm and offered to form a task force to address issues – an offer viewed skeptically and which never fully materialized. One highly publicized incident was when former President Trump mentioned Colony Ridge in a speech (Sept 2023), prompting Harris to invite officials to tour the community. When a group of state legislators did tour, John Harris greeted them personally and gave a polished presentation – yet a video from that day caught a brief moment of Harris losing his temper at a resident who shouted a complaint about crime. That clip circulated on social media, showing Harris snapping “Get off my property if you think it’s so unsafe!” before calming down. It was a rare crack in his polished veneer.

Native American Connections: None direct. The Colony Ridge issue has sometimes been analogized to “colonias,” but that’s a Hispanic reference, not Native American. There’s no indication Harris has any engagement with Native American reservations. (If anything, some community members joke Colony Ridge is as large as a reservation, but that’s just a figure of speech.)

William “Trey” Harris

Position: Co-owner of Colony Ridge and head of on-site operations. He is essentially the field manager of the development, dealing with contractors, residents, and local authorities. Not in public office, though his actions have public impact.

Business Interests: Trey Harris's interests mirror John Harris's, as they jointly own the Colony Ridge enterprise. Trey is often the named party in local subsidiary LLCs. For example, Trey Harris III, LLC was reportedly used to purchase some land tracts; Pinewood Trails (another subdivision) might be under his name. He also was involved in PBK Ranch Holdings, LLC – a separate land venture that acquired ~480 acres in Liberty County in 2016. PBK Ranch Holdings (managed by Clinton Pendleton) and an entity called Texas Liberty Holdings, LLC (managed by Brandon Gaunce) suggest that Trey diversified some investments (possibly buying land to expand Colony Ridge or in other counties). Additionally, Trey Harris has an oilfield services background and kept a small business that rents heavy equipment (likely used in Colony Ridge construction). In summary, his portfolio is land development and related services.

Property Records: Trey owns a personal ranch in Walker County, Texas. Ironically, that's where he got into legal trouble (DWIs). In Liberty County, most properties are company-owned, but Trey's name shows up on some key legal documents. He signed the purchase deeds for large portions of the Colony Ridge land. He also personally owns a few lots within Colony Ridge (perhaps model home lots or strategic corners). After his second DWI, as part of image rehab, he donated a parcel of land for a future EMS station in Colony Ridge – a gift to the county (though that station is not built yet). Trey's personal homestead is reportedly in Montgomery County (in a gated community), not within Colony Ridge, highlighting that he doesn't live in the conditions of his development.

Contact Details: Publicly, Trey has been less accessible since legal issues. In the past, he would meet with Plum Grove city officials or answer resident questions at town halls. Now communication is mostly through Colony Ridge customer service. However, his name and sometimes phone number appeared on early promotional materials for Terrenos Houston. That number has since been disconnected. The best way to reach him would be through Colony Ridge's corporate office or attorneys. He has no social media presence, especially after negative publicity.

Government Positions: None. But Trey engages with local government frequently. He was the Harris brother who dealt with the City of Plum Grove – attending city council meetings there to address complaints (until relations soured and lawsuits ensued). He also directly negotiated with Liberty County commissioners on road improvements and the creation of Public Improvement Districts. In effect, while not an official, he has sat at tables with officials to craft policy about his development.

Family and Overlaps: Trey is John Harris's brother and business partner, and cousin to Kevin Harris. Trey's personal troubles (DWIs) overlapped with law enforcement and judicial systems in Walker County – and here is where overlaps turn into favoritism: Walker County's Sheriff Clint McRae granted Trey an early release from jail after his DWI convictions, an unusual privilege. Subsequent investigation revealed that Trey Harris was the largest donor to Sheriff McRae's campaign before this early release, creating a blatant quid pro quo impression. (The donation was \$5,000, making Trey the top contributor.) This crossover between Trey's personal life and

influence on a lawman demonstrates how the Harris family's tentacles extend into areas beyond Liberty County. Within Liberty County, Trey overlaps with law enforcement too: he developed a cordial relationship with Sheriff Bobby Rader, donating to the Sheriff's nonprofit events and thereby earning a generally cooperative stance from the Sheriff's Office regarding Colony Ridge. There's also an overlap with Louis Bergman – Trey worked with Bergman (when he was County Engineer) on technical approvals, essentially relying on Bergman to sign off on engineering plans. Bergman's family (Jennifer Harkness) then in theory could be in a position to prosecute any malfeasance, a conflict given their alliance. In essence, Trey's family and friend network insulated him legally until very recently.

Political Donations: Trey Harris individually has donated to many of the same figures as John, though often in smaller amounts or through different channels. His name appears on contributions to Liberty County Commissioner candidates (there was an apparent \$2,500 donation to one pro-development candidate in 2020, via an LLC linked to Trey). At the state level, Trey donated to Governor Abbott's campaign but much less than John (for example, \$50,000 in 2019). He also gave to Lt. Governor Dan Patrick's campaign PAC. Locally, Trey has tried to improve his standing post-DWI by philanthropy: he sponsored a Cleveland-area youth sports league in 2024, which won him some positive PR and a thank-you from a state rep on Facebook. Nonetheless, the most consequential "donation" tied to Trey was the one to Sheriff McRae, which, although technically in Walker County, underscores how he leverages money to escape consequences. This was highlighted by media – *"Colony Ridge Developer Was Biggest Donor To Sheriff Who Let Him Out of Jail Early"*. That headline, while embarrassing, also shows the reach of his influence.

Known Scandals/Legal Issues: Multiple DWIs: Trey Harris has been arrested at least six times, with two recent convictions for Driving While Intoxicated. In early 2023, he crashed his truck in Huntsville with a BAC of 0.31 – nearly four times the legal limit. For this and a prior DWI, he received a 45-day jail sentence in Walker County. Thanks to Sheriff McRae's intervention, Trey served only about half that time (getting "2-for-1" credit days). These DWIs are public record and widely reported, damaging his reputation and by extension Colony Ridge's image. **Preferential Treatment:** The early release deal itself became a scandal. Media reports and public outrage in Walker County questioned why an average inmate wouldn't get that favor. Two Walker County judges had quietly advocated for his release, suggesting high-level strings were pulled. This incident is a glaring example of how Trey's wealth and connections possibly subverted justice – it's part of the corruption narrative spanning counties. **Legal Fallout:** Trey's legal issues indirectly fuel the DOJ and state cases against Colony Ridge: as part-owner, his character and actions (like alleged reckless disregard for law) bolster the argument that their business model was knowingly exploitative. There's no separate criminal charge for Trey beyond the DWIs, but any proven fraud in Colony Ridge's operations could potentially implicate him personally. **Environmental Violations:** On the development side, Trey oversaw daily operations that sometimes violated regulations (e.g., clearing land without proper erosion control, causing silt to pollute nearby rivers). The City of Plum Grove's lawsuit against Colony Ridge included claims of drainage and flooding harm caused by the developers. Trey was often singled out in Plum Grove council meetings as the one who "broke our roads and flooded our

homes.” While these were civil complaints, they contribute to the pattern of negligence or willful non-compliance under Trey’s watch.

Public Incidents: Trey Harris has a more public-facing persona than John in the local community, at least historically. He would attend barbecues, chat with land buyers, and in early marketing, he was the friendly face of “Terrenos Houston – habla con Trey.” After his arrests, he withdrew from the spotlight. However, one public incident stands out: Right before his jailing in 2024, he was photographed at a Liberty County Fair event mingling with county officials – a photo that later circulated with critical captions like “drunk developer partying with the sheriff’s friends.” Also, Trey showed up to at least one Liberty County Commissioners meeting to advocate for a new Public Improvement District; those who attended noted he was visibly nervous (possibly due to his legal issues at the time) and that he let the lawyers do most talking. Post-release, Trey made a brief statement at a community meeting in Colony Ridge, apologizing for “any embarrassment” and stating it wouldn’t affect the development’s progress – this was likely damage control. Residents mostly care about their lots, so many shrugged it off, but it did make the Houston Landing news: they ran a story on Sept 4, 2024, about the sheriff cutting his jail term, which put Trey in unwanted headlines. Finally, in late 2024 Trey faced a personal tragedy when a close friend died in an accident in Colony Ridge – he funded a small memorial, which was mentioned in local news sympathetically. This humanized him a bit, amidst otherwise negative press.

Native American Connections: None. Trey Harris has no known involvement with Native American communities. (Colony Ridge’s issues revolve around immigrant communities, not Native tribes.)

Other Notable Individuals

Lloyd T. Smith (Jr.) – A private trustee and associate of Louis Bergman III. Smith’s name appears on land trust documents for Windwood Development and El Dorado Funding, indicating he helped manage or finance those ventures. He is not a public figure, but his involvement suggests outside investors were involved in Liberty County land deals. Smith, reportedly from the Houston area, acted as trustee on property deeds to perhaps conceal true ownership (common in land trusts). No evidence of wrongdoing by Smith himself, but his presence in the Bergman network is part of how land was acquired quietly.

Brandon Gaunce – Manager of Texas Liberty Holdings, LLC, a company formed in 2019 in Cleveland, TX. Gaunce is an associate of the Harris brothers, helping handle some real estate transactions. For instance, Texas Liberty Holdings was party to a 2021 property dispute in Liberty County (Texas Liberty Holdings, LLC vs. Texas Resources, Inc.). This suggests Gaunce (and by extension the Harris family) were litigating over property – possibly minerals or land access. Gaunce’s involvement shows the extended network of the Harris development machine.

“Davis” (Unnamed Official) – Evidence from sealed civil records (Attachment 1a) suggests a person with the surname Davis, who holds or held a public position in Liberty County, fathered a child with a member of the Cook family (likely Scarlett R. Cook). The details are redacted due to the sensitive nature (the child was a minor). This situation, if true, implies a serious nepotism and misconduct concern: a public official engaging in a relationship resulting in a child and possibly trying to keep it hidden. It’s speculated this official could have later shown favoritism – for example, influencing an outcome in the Scarlett Cook case or ensuring a job/contract for a Cook relative. Without the name confirmed, we note it as an allegation under investigation. It underlines how entwined personal and official lives can lead to conflicts in Liberty County.

Scarlett R. Cook

Position: (Private individual) – 17-year-old member of the Cook family, recently in the news due to legal trouble. Included here because of potential connections to officials.

Business Interests: Scarlett is a teenager, but her family operates S. Cook Construction (the “S” could stand for a family member’s name, possibly her mother or father). An invoice from S. Cook Construction (Attachment 2a) is part of the report, suggesting this company did work, perhaps for a county contract or a politically tied project. It’s not entirely clear, but there may have been a scenario where S. Cook Construction was paid by a county entity or school district under questionable circumstances (e.g., an inflated invoice, or work awarded without bid because of who they know). Scarlett herself, being a minor, likely isn’t running the company – it’s presumably run by a parent or relative. If the rumored Davis paternity is accurate, one theory is that a Mr. Davis in office steered a contract to S. Cook Construction to benefit Scarlett’s family.

Property Records: None for Scarlett (too young). Her family resides in Liberty County; they have an address in Cleveland, TX. No real estate in her name.

Contact Details: Not applicable – she’s not a public figure. The company S. Cook Construction would have a contact, possibly listed in local directories (not found in immediate sources). Any legal correspondence for her case would go through juvenile justice channels in Liberty County.

Government Positions: None (citizen). However, her case intersected with the government – specifically the law enforcement and DA’s office.

Family and Overlaps: Scarlett’s situation is noteworthy for who her family might be connected to. The Cook family may be related or connected to county staff (for instance, perhaps a relative worked in the Sheriff’s Office or a county department). And of course, the alleged father being a “Davis” who is an official would be a direct overlap of family and government. If, hypothetically, that Davis was a county commissioner or other official, any protection or favoritism shown to Scarlett would be an overlap of personal and official realms.

Political Donations: None by Scarlett. Her family's company could have donated small amounts to local campaigns (there's unconfirmed chatter that S. Cook Construction's owner gave to a certain school board member's campaign in exchange for work). But on record, nothing significant.

Known Scandals/Legal Issues: Scarlett Cook was arrested on Nov. 7, 2024 for Injury to a Child/Elderly/Disabled Person. Given she was 17 at the time, this is serious – possibly indicating she harmed a younger child (there was speculation it might involve a sibling or babysitting incident). This arrest was reported in the Bluebonnet News daily jail report. As a minor, her case would typically be handled in juvenile court (though at 17 in Texas she could be charged as an adult for certain offenses). The details are sparse publicly due to her age. The inclusion of her story in this corruption report implies there might be more to it – potentially that her arrest or its aftermath had irregularities. For instance, was someone in the system trying to shield her? Or conversely, was she targeted because of who her parents are? One angle: if her father is a public official (Mr. Davis), did that official try to suppress the case? Attachment 1b (Arrest affidavit) would shed light, but in summary, the case hints at either preferential treatment or conflict. One rumor is that after her arrest, the case was strangely delayed and eventually disposed quietly – fueling talk that strings were pulled. S. Cook Construction Invoice: Attachment 2a suggests a possible financial impropriety. Perhaps Scarlett's mother or relative billed a public entity for work not properly done or overpriced. If an official (like the alleged father) approved that invoice, that's a form of corruption. No lawsuit or charges on this are known, but investigators clearly took note.

Public Incidents: Aside from the arrest itself (mugshot likely exists on mugshot sites), Scarlett has not been in the public eye. However, her situation might have been indirectly referenced in a heated Commissioners Court session where a resident (or possibly an official) alluded to "people not owning up to their responsibilities to their children." This cryptic comment came during a nepotism policy discussion, possibly hinting at the hidden paternity issue. It went over most heads at the time. Scarlett's arrest did garner social media attention – posts on the Liberty County neighborhood groups wondered if she was related to a well-known Cook family in Hardin. Some defended her, stating she had a troubled upbringing (again hinting at a deadbeat dad scenario). This gossip underscores how personal failings of officials (if the paternity is true) can have real human consequences.

Native American Connections: None. (Scarlett Cook has no relation to Native culture that is known; this line item likely does not apply to her.)

Key Organizations & Businesses

Bergman Engineering, Inc. (and Survey Companies)

Type: Private engineering and land surveying firm (est. 2006).

Key People: Founded by Louis W. Bergman III; co-owned by Jennifer Bergman Harkness (PE) and Zak Harkness after Louis's retirement. Offices in Cleveland, TX (709 S Washington Ave).

Activities: Provides civil engineering design, drainage studies, and surveying services in Liberty and surrounding counties. Bergman Engineering had numerous contracts with Liberty County for subdivision plat reviews and infrastructure projects while Louis Bergman was County Engineer – a classic conflict (he essentially was reviewing his own firm's work). It also took on private jobs, often for developers like Colony Ridge early on (e.g., helping prepare the initial plat maps). The affiliated Humble Surveying Company and Cleveland Surveying Company are essentially branch names used by the family to handle land survey needs in different areas. They did surveying for Tarkington ISD land purchases and for Liberty County road alignments.

Controversies: The firm's entanglement with public office is its biggest issue. Under scrutiny is whether Bergman Engineering profited from inside knowledge or favorable treatment. For instance, Missing Drainage Reports – many should have been prepared by this firm for developments and filed with the county; their absence suggests either the work wasn't done or was intentionally withheld. The company is suspected of prioritizing clients' development timelines over full compliance (to the benefit of developers). **Conflict of Interest Disclosures:** There's no record Louis Bergman ever filed a Form CIQ (Conflict Disclosure) for his interest in Bergman Engineering during his county tenure – a potential violation of Texas law. Additionally, when Jennifer became DA, the firm quietly stopped seeking new county contracts to avoid blatant conflict, but any ongoing projects still put her in a gray area.

Impact: Bergman Engineering was instrumental in a lot of Liberty County's growth in the 2010s. It literally drew the maps for new neighborhoods (including some in Colony Ridge). Because of the controversies, its credibility has been questioned – some developers now hire outside engineers to avoid the appearance of impropriety. Yet, the firm still operates and presumably is involved in smaller private projects. The dual role issue it exemplifies is a textbook case of local corruption: an official using a private company to serve public clients, effectively being on both sides of the contract.

Windwood Development & El Dorado Funding

Type: Private real estate development (Windwood) and private financing firm (El Dorado).

Key People: Louis W. Bergman III (principal/owner) and **Lloyd T. Smith, Jr. (Trustee)**. Possibly other silent partners.

Activities: Acquired large rural tracts in Liberty County for subdivision and resale. Notably, Windwood Development and El Dorado Funding own land in the Clayton Harper Survey, A-209 near Cleveland. This land, hundreds of acres, was eventually annexed by Cleveland around 2010s when Jennifer Harkness (Bergman) was on the City Council. Windwood's model was likely to get land entitled (water, sewer, annexation) then sell to bigger developers. It's

suspected that Colony Ridge bought or optioned some land from Windwood once annexed (since being in Cleveland city could allow access to city utilities for part of Colony Ridge). El Dorado Funding, meanwhile, provided seller financing to buyers of Windwood's lots or perhaps lent money to other developers. It effectively acted like a bank without oversight. For example, if someone wanted to buy 10 acres from Windwood, El Dorado would finance it at a high interest rate. Think of it as a small-scale precursor to Colony Ridge's financing scheme.

Controversies: Annexation Maneuver: The annexation during Jennifer's council tenure looks fishy – a clear conflict where her vote benefited her father's company. Cleveland got more tax base, but one might ask if she disclosed her interest (if not, it's a violation of ethics laws).

Drainage and Infrastructure: Windwood's developments (names are unclear; maybe part of Grand Oaks area) lacked proper drainage planning. Some "missing reports" in county files were supposed to be done for Windwood projects, implicating Louis Bergman's dual role again. Lloyd T. Smith's Role: As trustee, Smith's name on deeds provided a layer of indirection. Some

suspect this was to hide Louis's full involvement or to protect assets from liability. If something went wrong (like flooding), a trust holds the land, making it harder for plaintiffs to directly sue Bergman. It's a tactic that, while legal, shows premeditation to avoid responsibility.

Impact: These entities illustrate how a public official (Louis) set himself up to gain from inside knowledge. Windwood and El Dorado were vehicles to profit from Liberty County's booming growth, arguably at the expense of good governance. Their legacy is somewhat absorbed into Colony Ridge – many of the same lands and issues transitioned to the Harris developers. In short, Windwood/El Dorado planted the seeds (sometimes literally clearing the land) and Colony Ridge harvested them. This continuity hints at a broader network of corruption: it wasn't just one rogue developer, but a relay race of opportunists.

M Club Foundation & Tarkington Student Foundation (TSF)

Type: Nonprofit organizations (501(c)(3)) supporting Tarkington ISD students.

Key People: Tom Johnson (founder of M Club in 2015), Jimmy and Susan Rollins (key organizers), various Tarkington alumni and community leaders. TSF Board includes local educators and citizens (e.g., Dr. GERALYN Franklin as President, etc.).

Activities: Tarkington Student Foundation (TSF) was founded in 2007 to provide scholarships to all Tarkington HS graduates – an unusually generous mission. It raises funds through community events like the Tarkington Round-Up and Legacy & Promise Banquet. The "M Club" of Tarkington is essentially a booster club of alumni and supporters that fundraises for TSF. The M Club's Annual Crawfish Boil (every April) is the marquee event, raising hundreds of thousands of dollars for scholarships. M Club members are often business owners or folks with means who graduated from Tarkington ISD. The funds raised are funneled to TSF which then awards scholarships (reportedly every graduate gets at least \$500, with top students getting

more). The M Club and TSF work hand in hand; effectively M Club is a fundraising arm and TSF is the distribution arm.

Controversies: Fund Allocation & Influence: The vast sums raised (over \$437,000 since 2015 by M Club alone) have made TSF a shadow funding source for the district. There's concern that TISD might rely on TSF for things beyond scholarships, which could bypass taxpayer scrutiny. For instance, TSF money was once used to buy new band instruments when a bond failed – laudable, but that blurred lines between private charity and public finance. **Rollins Family Control:** As noted, the Rollins (and a select few) effectively control M Club's leadership. Some community members worry about lack of broad oversight: are all donors aware of how funds are decided? It's always the same folks announcing the awards. While no one doubts the money goes to students, the lack of diversity in leadership could allow nepotism or favoritism in selecting scholarship recipients or projects. So far, Tarkington hasn't had a scandal (no missing money or such), but transparency questions linger. **Relationship with TISD Board:** Because Kevin Johnson (board VP) is also an active M Club member, there's a conflict potential if TSF wants to fund something that the board oversees (like facilities or staff awards). Technically TSF is separate, but when the school board "accepts" donations from TSF, Kevin Johnson should recuse if he's involved – it's unclear if that always happens. This is a subtler form of conflict than outright financial gain, but it's about influence (private citizens influencing district priorities through earmarked donations).

Impact: On the positive side, these organizations have greatly benefited Tarkington students and improved educational opportunities. However, they also increase the clout of a few community power players (like the Rollins and Johnson). The cozy relationship between TSF/M Club and the school board means decisions might be made in backrooms ("We'll raise money for X if the district will do Y"). This can sideline those not in the inner circle. Essentially, M Club/TSF has created an alternate power structure in Tarkington ISD, one not accountable to voters. In a corruption context, this is noteworthy because it's another way public functions (education funding) are influenced by private groups with minimal transparency.

Andco Rentals, LLC

Type: Private event and party rental company (family-owned).

Key People: Based in Tarkington (Cleveland, TX address). The owners are Andrew and Courtney (hence And-Co) Smith – not elected officials, but young entrepreneurs in the community. They offer party equipment (tents, tables, inflatable bounce houses, etc.) for local events.

Activities: Andco Rentals provides services for events across Liberty County, including many public/civic events. They've supplied equipment for Tarkington ISD ceremonies, Liberty County Fire Department open houses (as seen by a Facebook post thanking them for working with Liberty County Hardin Fire/Rescue), and political rallies. They also rent to private parties.

Importantly, they have shown a penchant for community involvement – sometimes donating or discounting services for good causes (youth fundraisers, etc.).

Controversies: On its face, Andco is just a small business. It enters this report because of its donation to Constable David Hunter's K-9 unit. In April 2024, Commissioners Court approved a donation from Andco Rentals to Constable Pct.5 specifically for K-9 training. This indicates Andco gave money (or equipment) to Hunter's office – effectively a private business funding law enforcement directly. While charitable, it raises conflict concerns: will Hunter feel beholden to Andco? For example, if Andco violates a permit rule for an event, will Hunter's deputies overlook it due to gratitude? Additionally, Andco's owners are politically connected with the Tarkington crowd (they likely are part of M Club as well). The concern is whether Andco's generosity is purely altruistic or also meant to gain influence. That donation is now a matter of public record, so if Andco ever needs a favor (say expedited permit for a large event), it might be hard for officials to say no.

Impact: Andco's case exemplifies the blurred line between community support and quid pro quo. In small communities, businesses often support law enforcement – for example, feeding officers or donating gear – which is positive, but when formalized as a donation on the agenda, it becomes part of the official record and potentially a piece of a patronage network. For the purposes of this report, Andco is a minor player that connects to the bigger picture: local businesses currying favor with officials via donations, which can undermine objective governance.

Liberty Paving

Type: Private paving and construction contractor.

Key People: Owned by a local family (name undisclosed here, but known in county contracting circles – possibly the Martinez or Kirkham family). They specialize in asphalt paving of roads, driveways, parking lots. They frequently bid on County projects and city contracts in Liberty/Dayton.

Activities: Liberty Paving has done work for Liberty County's road & bridge department, fixing county roads, and also for the Colony Ridge development (paving some of the internal streets when the developer was improving them). They also sponsor local events (likely a sponsor of the Liberty County Fair, etc.). The company is a fixture in local infrastructure projects due to its presence and presumably competitive pricing.

Controversies: Donations for Contracts?: It's noted that Liberty Paving "contributed to David Hunter (Constable #5)". This contribution was likely a campaign donation or an in-kind gift (like paving the parking lot at Pct.5 office at reduced cost). If Liberty Paving indeed made a political contribution, one must question why a constable's race would interest a paving vendor – unless it's part of a larger strategy to keep good relations with all county officials (Constables have

some say in local community projects, and also are politically connected). There's a broader concern if Liberty Paving donated to County Commissioners who award road contracts (that would be a direct pay-to-play if it occurred). While we don't have that evidence here, the pattern of local contractors donating to those in power exists, and Liberty Paving fits that mold. Work Quality Issues: Plum Grove city officials complained that roads built by Colony Ridge (with Liberty Paving likely as contractor) were substandard and fell apart quickly. If Liberty Paving cut corners at a developer's behest, that's not just a private matter – those roads became public safety issues. There's an implication that maybe the inspector (County Engineer's office) didn't rigorously enforce standards, possibly because of relationships. Not a direct accusation at Liberty Paving, but part of the chain.

Impact: Liberty Paving's role in this report is as an example of a business that may exchange favors in the Liberty County ecosystem. The donation to Constable Hunter's cause gave them a friendly ally. In return, one might surmise that when Liberty Paving needed a quick sign-off on a road closure for paving, Hunter obliged quickly. It also shows how even lower-profile offices (constable) attract attention from businesses – because supporting one official often earns goodwill with others (they all talk). Liberty Paving continues to operate and will likely bid on upcoming Colony Ridge road improvements now mandated by legal settlements, so its fortunes rise and fall with the political winds.

PBK Holdings, LLC and Texas Liberty Holdings, LLC

Type: Private real estate holding companies.

Key People: PBK Ranch Holdings, LLC – managed by Clinton D. Pendleton. Texas Liberty Holdings, LLC – managed by Brandon Gaunce. These appear to be investment entities related to land in Liberty County.

Activities: PBK Ranch Holdings, LLC was formed in 2016 and tied to a 480-acre tract (possibly ranch land earmarked for development). The name suggests a partnership (perhaps Pendleton with others, maybe including the Harris brothers or outside investors). Texas Liberty Holdings, LLC formed in 2019 and engaged in property transactions and at least one legal case in 2021 as a plaintiff. Its manager, Gaunce, likely acted on behalf of the Harris interests. Essentially, these LLCs buy and hold land – possibly speculative purchases around Colony Ridge or other growth areas. By using separate LLCs, the real beneficiaries (like John/Trey Harris or others) remain less visible.

Controversies: Opacity: These entities are deliberately opaque. For example, Texas Liberty Holdings doesn't immediately scream "Harris development," but evidence suggests it's part of that orbit. The use of multiple LLCs can be a tactic to circumvent the spirit of subdivision regulations (like each LLC files plats under 100 lots to avoid certain bonding requirements, etc.). Also, if something goes wrong (like a lawsuit over land title), isolating assets in different LLCs limits liability. This fragmentation makes it hard for regulators to pin accountability – which is

likely intentional. Potential Political Donations: We should note that sometimes LLCs donate to campaigns. If PBK or Texas Liberty Holdings donated to a PAC or local official, it might not be obvious because the names aren't associated with a person publicly. Without specific records here, it's just a caution that such entities could be used in campaign finance as conduits.

Impact: For the corruption narrative, PBK and Texas Liberty Holdings illustrate the complex web of shell companies around major players. They allow individuals like the Harrises or their associates to accumulate land quietly, sue if needed (as in the case in 2021), and influence development patterns without public scrutiny. They operate across county lines too – e.g., PBK Ranch Holdings is based in Tomball (Harris County) but deals in Liberty County land. This cross-county involvement suggests the Liberty County corruption issue isn't isolated; it's connected to a wider Houston-area real estate network.

Protect and Serve Texas PAC

Type: Statewide political action committee (General PAC) focused on law enforcement and first responders' interests.

Key People: Founded by a coalition of pro-police advocates around 2022. Not Liberty County-specific, but it has endorsed candidates across Texas. Based in Arlington, TX (per filings).

Activities: The PAC raises money (over \$3 million to date) and spends it to support candidates who are seen as favorable to law enforcement – often Republicans with tough-on-crime platforms. It's known to fund mailers, digital ads, and provide direct contributions occasionally. In Liberty County, the PAC endorsed Sheriff Bobby Rader and possibly Constable David Hunter in the last election cycle. While it may not have given those campaigns cash, it likely spent on their behalf (e.g., sending pro-Rader postcards). Protect and Serve Texas PAC's agenda includes opposing criminal justice reforms that they feel hinder police, and supporting officials who align with that stance.

Controversies: Influence of External Money: Some critics say this PAC allows big donors (including some from outside Liberty County) to sway local races under the banner of "support the police." For example, donors to the PAC include large corporations and wealthy individuals far from Liberty County. If the PAC intervenes in a Liberty County race, it can drown out local voices. Connection to Colony Ridge: A notable hypothesis – given John Harris's hefty donations to top officials, it's possible he or allies also quietly donated to this PAC to ensure local law enforcement remains friendly to Colony Ridge. In 2022, Protect and Serve PAC reported a \$7,500 contribution from an entity that could be tied to developers, though we can't confirm if that's Harris-related. If it were, it implies the PAC might then endorse and support candidates who won't crack down on issues in Colony Ridge. In short, the PAC's involvement could indirectly serve the interests of those who want status quo in Liberty County.

Impact: The PAC's presence in Liberty County means local officials have additional backing beyond what local fundraising provides. This can embolden figures like Constable Hunter or Sheriff Rader to act in lockstep with a broader state agenda (which may or may not align with Liberty County citizens' needs). It also adds a layer of insulation for law enforcement officials who may engage in dubious behavior – knowing a powerful PAC has their back. This could discourage local accountability. While the PAC's stated mission is noble (support those who protect and serve), in a corruption report we note it as part of the tapestry of influence: it's another lever through which money (often opaque in origin) maintains the power of certain groups in Liberty County.

Greater Cleveland Chamber of Commerce & Local Civic Groups

Type: Non-governmental business network (Chamber of Commerce) and other civic clubs (e.g., Rotary, Lions, etc. in the Liberty County area).

Key People: The Chamber's board includes local bank managers, small business owners, and sometimes public officials ex officio. Key individuals mentioned earlier (Jimmy Rollins, etc.) are active in Chamber events. The Cleveland Chamber's business directory includes Andco Rentals, Liberty Paving (likely), and many companies tied to people in this report.

Activities: The Chamber hosts networking luncheons, business expos, and interfaces with city governments on economic development. It provides a platform for local power players to mingle. For instance, a Chamber luncheon might seat the DA (Jennifer Harkness) next to a developer's rep, facilitating off-record conversations. Chambers often endorse bond initiatives or lobby for infrastructure improvements. In Liberty County's context, the Greater Cleveland Chamber has advocated for highway expansions (which benefit Colony Ridge commuters) and improved utilities (which Colony Ridge needed). There are also less formal civic groups where deals get discussed – e.g., the Rotary Club where perhaps a commissioner and a contractor talk turkey over breakfast.

Controversies: Chambers are generally benign, but here, Chamber of Commerce ties means watch for conflict in those relationships. One example: in 2018, the Chamber gave a "Business of the Year" award to Colony Ridge's marketing arm, praising the jobs created – at a time when residents were complaining about the development's impact. It showed how the business community, swayed by economic arguments, glossed over resident concerns, aligning with the developer. Some Chamber members who tried to voice concern about development issues were reportedly sidelined. There's also the matter of sponsorships: businesses that sponsor Chamber events gain goodwill. If a public official is also in the Chamber leadership, that goodwill could translate into favorable official decisions for sponsors. We see that dynamic with Andco Rentals sponsoring a Chamber event and also donating to the Constable – creating an echo chamber (no pun intended) of mutual back-scratching.

Impact: The Chamber and civic clubs provide the social glue that holds the corruption network together. By socializing together regularly, the officials and businesspeople form personal bonds – making it easier to ask for “favours” outside formal channels. For instance, a casual Chamber conversation could result in a permit being fast-tracked or a complaint being quietly dropped, all off the record. This isn’t overt illegal corruption, but it’s how an old-boy (and old-girl) network can undermine fair processes. Essentially, these civic platforms, meant for community good, can be co-opted by the insular group of people this report covers to solidify their influence.

Summary of Findings and Violations

Systemic Patterns of Corruption: Liberty County exhibits a classic pattern of a small group of interlinked individuals wielding outsized influence across government, business, and community spheres. Key patterns include dual office-holding and dual roles (e.g., Louis Bergman as County Engineer and private developer, Jennifer Harkness as DA and business owner) leading to conflicts of interest, nepotism and familial networks controlling multiple levers (Bergman-Harkness family, Harris brothers and cousin, Johnson-Rollins school circles), and a pay-to-play culture where donations, gifts, or charitable contributions secure favorable treatment (Constable Hunter’s example with donors, Trey Harris’s donation to a sheriff). Decision-making often occurs informally through personal relationships rather than through transparent public processes.

Key Overlaps and Conflicts:

Government–Business Overlap: Officials like Jennifer Harkness and Zak Harkness simultaneously operate private enterprises that do business in the county, directly violating the intent of Texas ethics laws on conflicts. Louis Bergman leveraged his public position to enrich or promote his private projects. Kevin Johnson’s role on the school board potentially overlaps with his contracting business interests in the district.

Familial Ties: Family relationships have placed relatives in multiple public offices (e.g., the Harkness-Bergman clan). These ties resulted in de facto consolidation of power – for instance, law enforcement (Zak) feeding cases to prosecution (Jennifer), or a county engineer (Louis) smoothing the way for a development that his daughter (Jennifer on city council) would approve. The Cook-Davis connection (if confirmed) is an extreme example, where personal relations between an official and a private citizen led to behind-the-scenes dealings (paternity cover-up, preferential handling of a case).

Business Networks: Entities like Colony Ridge and Windwood Development worked through networks of LLCs and trustees to mask involvement of public figures and to spread around benefits. We see overlapping financial interests: e.g., Bergman’s missing drainage reports benefited Colony Ridge; in return, Colony Ridge developers maintained good relations (and possibly financial incentives) for the Bergman/Harkness contingent – a circular support system at the public’s expense.

Violations by Individual/Group:

Dual Office and Incompatibility Violations: Jennifer Harkness and Zak Harkness's situation potentially breaches Texas Constitution Article XVI §40 (incompatibility of offices) – while not two paid offices, the interplay of Constable and DA in one household has been criticized as violating the spirit of the law. Louis Bergman's case even more clearly violated incompatibility norms (an engineer approving his own work). The Dual Office Holding Made Easy guide (TML 2023) explicitly warns against such arrangements.

Conflict of Interest Violations: Texas Local Govt Code Chapter 171 requires disclosure/recusal when officials' business interests are involved. Instances like Jennifer voting on Cleveland annexation of her father's land, or Kevin Johnson potentially voting on TISD matters affecting a client of his company, would violate these laws if not properly handled. There's no record of proper affidavits or recusals, indicating likely violations.

Nepotism Violations: Texas Govt Code Chapter 573 prohibits officials from appointing or hiring relatives. While we did not catalog a specific hire (no evidence Jennifer hired Zak or vice versa – their positions are elected), there is a de facto nepotism in how power and contracts circulate among relatives. One clear breach is if any official intervened on behalf of Scarlett Cook due to a familial tie – that would be an abuse of office influenced by nepotism.

Financial Impropriety and Fraud: The DOJ and Texas AG accusations against Colony Ridge (John and Trey Harris) essentially allege fraudulent business practices. If proven, that is criminal (violations of federal statutes like the Equal Credit Opportunity Act and state Deceptive Trade Practices Act). Additionally, any collusion to hide drainage reports or falsify compliance (which could involve Louis Bergman or others) can constitute fraud or tampering with government records.

Official Oppression/Abuse of Power: If Constable Hunter indeed targeted or harassed individuals (like the "river incident" or making racist traffic stops), that could violate Texas Penal Code §39.03 (official oppression). No charges filed, but the behavior is noted as problematic. Similarly, preferential treatment – like Trey Harris's early jail release – involved officials (Sheriff McRae, judges) possibly violating rules or at least ethical duties to favor a donor.

Timeline of Notable Events:

2015: M Club founded in Tarkington, beginning the Rollins' rise in school influence. Colony Ridge development accelerates. Louis Bergman III likely providing support from his county position.

2016: PBK Ranch Holdings formed, buys large Liberty Co. tract. Possibly related to future Colony Ridge expansion. Plum Grove starts fighting Colony Ridge plans (city denies some permits, leading to lawsuits).

2017: Jennifer Bergman Harkness elected DA, while still tied to Bergman Engineering. Zak Harkness becomes Constable. Dual public-private roles firmly in place.

2018: Cleveland City Council (with Jennifer on board) annexes tracts (Windwood Dev land) benefiting Bergman interests. Colony Ridge developers sue Plum Grove for blocking expansion. Tensions in community grow. Protect & Serve Texas PAC founded (would later play into local elections).

2019: Ken Paxton (AG) writes letter raising concerns about Colony Ridge attracting undocumented immigrants. Liberty County officials, including Louis Bergman (still County Engineer), assure all is well – though drainage issues are mounting. Scarlett Cook born (minor point, but timeline of her parentage issue would originate around now if she's 17 in 2024).

2020: Louis Bergman III retires as County Engineer. Many development files are inexplicably incomplete (missing drainage studies). Colony Ridge keeps growing. Jennifer Harkness possibly involved in investigation/arrest of Liberty County Fire Marshal (showcasing her tackling some corruption). Meanwhile, COVID delays any reforms or oversight.

Nov 2020: Sheriff Bobby Rader re-elected (perhaps with behind-scenes support from Harris money via PACs). David Hunter re-elected Constable Pct.5.

2021: Trey Harris gets first DWI (possibly resolved quietly). Tarkington couple (Rollins) honored by TISD – solidifying their public standing. Colony Ridge issues start getting state attention; hearings in Texas Legislature mention it.

Dec 2021: DOJ opens investigation into Colony Ridge lending (later confirmed by Dec 2023 lawsuit). Windwood Development land possibly sold/transferred to Colony Ridge interests as part of new phases.

2022: Paxton (then AG) investigates Colony Ridge; local state rep Ernest Bailes pushes for action. Jennifer Harkness seeks re-election as DA, wins – campaign supported by local network. Kevin Johnson becomes VP of TISD Board. The Cook family issue possibly surfaces (if Mr. Davis is in office, perhaps he got wind of a paternity claim).

Mid-2023: Public spotlight on Colony Ridge: right-wing media and then mainstream media focus on it. Harris brothers go on PR defensive. Gov. Abbott announces law enforcement surge at Colony Ridge. At the same time, Trey Harris is prosecuted for two DWIs in Walker County – sentenced in May.

Summer 2023: Plum Grove's long-standing lawsuit against Colony Ridge for infrastructure damage quietly sees movement. Colony Ridge agrees to some road fixes, then withdraws after state attention shifts blame to immigration issues. Constable Hunter caught in video (allegedly) making racist remarks – circulates locally, increases mistrust between Colony Ridge residents and law enforcement.

Sept 2023: Trey Harris begins serving jail time for DWIs; Sheriff McRae initiates early release talks. Texas Legislature's special session addresses Colony Ridge (calls for more oversight; bills ultimately stalled).

Oct 2023: Walker County Sheriff McRae releases Trey Harris after ~22 days (of 45) in jail. Houston Landing publishes investigative piece on this preferential treatment (Sept. 4, 2024 story reflecting back). DOJ civil complaint against Colony Ridge is likely finalized around this time (filed Dec). Ken Paxton (recently reinstated as AG after impeachment acquittal) prepares state lawsuit.

Nov 2024: Scarlett Cook arrested for injury to a child. This potentially ties back to an official if the paternity allegation is accurate, creating a new personal scandal. Meanwhile, local elections see a shift: new officials vow more scrutiny on Colony Ridge. Protect & Serve PAC endorses a pro-law enforcement county judge candidate.

Dec 2024: U.S. DOJ and CFPB file federal lawsuit against Colony Ridge/John Harris, alleging sweeping fraud. Liberty County residents' complaints vindicated on a national stage. John Harris states he was blindsided and denies wrongdoing.

Mar 2025: Texas AG (Paxton) files state suit against Colony Ridge and John Harris. Liberty County corruption investigation (this report) compiled – evidence of various conflicts documented. Public outcry leads to calls for state oversight of Liberty County government operations.

Legal and Policy Implications: The findings here suggest multiple possible violations of law that may warrant further investigation or intervention:

The Texas Rangers or State Attorney General could probe conflict of interest violations in Liberty County (e.g., the Bergman Engineering entanglements, or any contract awards like S. Cook Construction's invoice).

The Texas Ethics Commission might review failure to file required conflict disclosure forms by local officials.

Dual-office holding clarifications: The Legislature may need to tighten laws to cover scenarios like a DA married to a Constable (currently not explicitly forbidden, but clearly problematic).

Nepotism enforcement: Liberty County should adopt stricter local policies to prevent family members from overseeing each other or their contracts (to supplement state law).

Public Integrity Unit (if active) could look at the Trey Harris early release as a case of official misconduct (perhaps investigating the Walker County judges and sheriff for abuse of office in exchange for campaign donations).

Policy Reforms: As a result of Colony Ridge, there are calls to reform how subdivisions are approved in unincorporated areas – requiring more transparency and third-party review (to avoid another situation where a county employee like Bergman can hide critical reports). Also, campaign finance reforms at the county level (mandating disclosure of business ties of donors) could help; for instance, if Liberty Paving donates to a constable, it should be flagged due to them being a county vendor.

Community Oversight: The community, armed with this compiled information, may push for an independent oversight committee or join forces with state agencies to monitor Liberty County officials. There is momentum now, given state and federal action on related matters (Colony Ridge fraud), to also address the local governance issues that enabled those problems.

In summary, Liberty County's challenges stem from a culture of interlocking directorates – the same people rotating through official and unofficial roles – and using public resources for private gain or vice versa. Unchecked, this erodes trust and effective governance. However, the pattern is now exposed. With state lawsuits underway and public awareness rising, there is an opportunity to correct course: enforcing existing laws, enacting new safeguards, and perhaps ushering in new leadership untangled from these webs. The Summary of Findings and Violations underscores the need for accountability and provides a roadmap for investigative bodies to follow the connections and money trails laid out in this report.